what happened on August 20th at 11 p.m.' when the US cruise missile slammed into their targets in Afghanistan.[57] This tactical shift meant that India would 'lie back [on the nuclear issue] and wait for the [US] administration's suddenly heightened preoccupation with Islamic terrorism to replace its upset over the Indian nuclear program'.[58]

New Delhi wanted to convince the US that a secular, democratic, and stable India was a better strategic partner in South Asia to challenge Islamist radicalism than Pakistan. But the US, Jaswant Singh argued, had to stop pressurising India to sign the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty.[59] The MEA kept its reaction to the US missile strikes equally mixed. While joining Washington in condemning international terrorism, the MEA cautioned the US against undertaking 'unilateral action'.[60] 'An effective international cooperative effort to identify and act against those responsible for international terrorism—whether individuals, terrorist groups, or states,' was advocated. The MEA's standard line was conditioned by the perception that India and the US had the same enemies, and similar friends. The UF buttressed this narrative in the Afghan context by emphasising that the US 'should target the fire, not the smoke' by attacking militant bases in Peshawar, Quetta, and Islamabad.[61] As India lobbied the US on the nuclear question, Al Qaeda's anti-West rhetoric steadily began to rise. In February 1998, the World Islamic Front led by bin Laden issued a statement castigating the US for 'occupying the lands of Islam in the holiest of places, the Arabian peninsula', and blaming the 'crusader-Zionist alliance' for conspiring against Islam.[62] Kashmir, Chechnya, Afghanistan, Africa and all regions experiencing Islamist extremism were on Al Qaeda's radar. Pakistan on the other hand, embarrassed and outraged for having lost its intelligence and military personnel in US missile strikes, condemned Washington for undertaking the strikes.

To further cement India and US cooperation on Afghanistan and terrorism, Vivek Katju (former JS of the Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Iran desk at the MEA) and Alok Prasad (deputy NSA) met Inderfurth on 2 September 1999, two months before the IC-814 hijacking. They wanted US support for Indian covert operations in Afghanistan, while Inderfurth, allegedly, wanted India to stop the Ariana flights (often loaded with ammunition and spare parts) between